

# THE NORSE

To truly understand the wonderful tales of Norse mythology, we need to know about the people who created and told them. Who were the Norse? How did they live their lives? And are there any truths behind these fantastic stories?

## FARM WORKERS

Many Norse warriors were also farmers. They tilled the land, all year round, from dawn until dusk. Women and children helped out on farms too. Some Norse stories tell of hard work, such as “The Mead of Poetry” in which Odin toils in the fields.



## WARRIORS

The Norse people, also called the Vikings, were feared across northern Europe from around 790 to 1050 CE. They staged lightning raids on neighbouring lands – killing, stealing and taking slaves. No wonder their myths are gruesome!

Norse farmers, helped by slaves called “thralls”, grew wheat, barley, rye and oats, and reared cattle, sheep, goats, pigs and hens. Fish and meat were preserved by salting and drying. They prayed to their gods and goddesses for a good harvest.



Just like the gods and giants, the Vikings fought with spears, axes, bows, knives and, occasionally, hammers. Only wealthy Vikings could afford swords.

For protection, wealthy Vikings wore domed iron helmets and chainmail. Poorer Vikings made do with thick, padded leather garments. All carried large, brightly coloured wooden shields.